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ARTICLE

Could The Backlash Against Artificial Intelligence Turn Violent?





BY PNW STAFF JULY 20, 2026

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The warning signs are no longer hypothetical.

An alleged attempted firebombing of OpenAI CEO Sam Altman's home. Death threats against executives at Anthropic. Online manifestos calling for the killing of AI leaders. Security teams escorting tech executives with armed protection. Threat-monitoring firms reporting a dramatic surge in violent rhetoric aimed at artificial intelligence companies and their massive data centers.

Just a few years ago, this would have sounded like science fiction.

Today, it is becoming reality.

Artificial intelligence is advancing at breathtaking speed, promising medical breakthroughs, scientific discoveries, economic growth, and productivity gains unlike anything seen since the Industrial Revolution. But for a growing number of people, AI represents something far different--a direct threat to their jobs, their communities, and perhaps even the future of human society.

That growing divide is creating one of the most significant cultural and political battles of the coming decade.

Fear Is Fueling The Backlash

To dismiss AI critics as simply anti-technology would be a mistake.

Many of their concerns are legitimate.

Entire professions are already being transformed. Writers, programmers, graphic designers, customer-service representatives, legal researchers, translators, accountants, and even medical professionals are discovering that AI can now perform work that once required years of education and experience.

History tells us new technologies eventually create new industries and new opportunities.

It also tells us the transition can be painful.

When people believe their livelihoods are disappearing, they rarely celebrate progress. As Palantir CEO Alex Karp recently observed, tell someone their job is about to disappear, and "people go for the pitchfork."

That may sound dramatic, but history offers plenty of examples. The Luddites of nineteenth-century England destroyed textile machinery they believed threatened their livelihoods. They failed to stop industrialization, but they demonstrated a timeless truth: when people feel technology is taking away their



future, some eventually attack the technology itself.

The Data Center Wars

The conflict isn't only about jobs.

It is increasingly about the enormous infrastructure required to power artificial intelligence.

Modern AI data centers consume staggering amounts of electricity and water. Proposed facilities have sparked opposition from residents worried about strained water supplies, increased electricity demand, environmental impacts, loss of farmland, and neighborhoods transformed by sprawling industrial campuses.

Some communities are also pushing back against rising property values fueled by tech investment, fearing they'll be priced out of the very places they've called home for generations.

To AI companies, these facilities represent the foundation of tomorrow's economy.

To many residents, they represent billion-dollar corporations consuming local resources while ordinary people bear the costs.

Those competing visions are setting the stage for increasingly bitter political battles.

A New Technology Divide

Supporters see AI as humanity's next great leap forward.

They envision faster medical discoveries, safer transportation, personalized education, greater productivity, and economic growth that could improve billions of lives.

Critics see something else entirely.

They worry about mass unemployment, deepfake deception, surveillance, concentrated corporate power, autonomous weapons, and a future where humans become increasingly dependent on machines they neither understand nor control.

Neither side is entirely wrong.

AI is likely to produce extraordinary benefits while also creating extraordinary disruption.

The problem is that both are likely to happen at the same time.



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Could The Conflict Escalate?

Most opposition to AI will remain peaceful.

But history reminds us that major technological revolutions rarely unfold without resistance.

Today it's death threats and Molotov cocktails.

Tomorrow it could be sabotaged data centers, blocked construction projects, damaged power infrastructure, or organized campaigns designed to halt AI expansion altogether. Around the world, infrastructure projects--from pipelines to power plants--have become flashpoints for years of protests and, in some cases, vandalism. There is little reason to assume AI facilities will be immune.

Imagine entire regions losing thousands of white-collar jobs over just a few years. Imagine AI companies simultaneously announcing record profits while building massive campuses that consume local land, water, and electricity.

The ingredients for a long-term political movement--and perhaps a far more confrontational one--are already visible.

Some have even begun asking a once-unthinkable question: could AI someday contribute to a form of civil conflict?

That should not be understood as a prediction. There is no evidence society is on the brink of armed conflict over artificial intelligence.

But technological revolutions have repeatedly intensified existing social and political divisions. If millions of people conclude that AI has permanently eliminated their careers while concentrating wealth and power into the hands of a few companies, resentment could grow into something far larger than today's isolated acts of violence.

Ironically, the conflict would never truly be humans versus robots.

It would be humans versus other humans, divided over what kind of civilization they want to build--and whether AI should define it.

More Than A Technology Debate

For Christians, this debate is about more than innovation.

Scripture consistently reminds us that human ingenuity is a gift, but also that wisdom must guide how every tool is used. Technology itself is neither righteous nor evil. The moral question has always been the human heart directing it.

Artificial intelligence may become one of the greatest tools humanity has ever created. It may also become one of the greatest sources of social disruption our generation has ever experienced.

The AI revolution is almost certainly coming.

The real question is not whether the technology will change civilization--it will. The question is whether society adapts, regulates, and benefits from that change, or whether fear, anger, and economic upheaval fuel an escalating backlash against those building it.



Every great technological revolution has created both winners and losers.

Artificial intelligence may create them faster than any revolution before it.

If that happens, the battle over AI may no longer be fought primarily in corporate boardrooms or legislative chambers--but in neighborhoods, at construction sites, and perhaps even in the streets.

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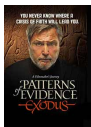
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